avoided assuming the highest readiness stage, as if to insure that Kennedy understood that the USSR would not launch first.'

According to the American military historian, Steven Zaloga:

> The strategic-bomber divisions began to move from their bases to their forward-staging bases, and they were armed with nuclear free-fall bombs. The R7A launchers at Plesetsk were readied and their flight-control systems wired for strikes against New York, Washington, Chicago, and other major U.S. cities. At the time of the Cuban missile crisis, two R-9 missiles were made operational at the Tyuratom proving ground. Several of the R-16 launch sites were also readied for launch.[49]

Robert Norris and Hans Kristensen record that some six R-7 and thirty-six R-16s were operational, together with one hundred Tupolev-95 [NATO-designation Bear] and sixty 3M [NATO-designation Bison] long-range bombers.[50]

Changes in alert and readiness states did not in themselves indicate intent to start a nuclear war (any more than did Soviet plans to instal MRBMs and IRBMs in Cuba). The changes were, nevertheless, of potential significance. On 16 October Robert McNamara suggested in ExComm that US strategic forces should be placed on alert. Any direct US military action against Cuba would provoke a Soviet military response. Therefore, he recommended 'mobilisation,' including a heightened nuclear alert:

> We must recognise it [Soviet military action] by trying to deter it, which means we probably should probably alert SAC, probably put on an airborne alert, perhaps take other alert measures. These brings risks of their own associated with them.[51]

He did not elaborate on the risks and his comments did not prompt discussion among his colleagues. There was no discussion of how Moscow might misperceive a heightened US state of alert as preparations for war. Nor did the meetings of the Joint Chiefs (which McNamara and Gilpatric attended) address possible Soviet misperception. And there was no